‘Hindutva Gives Gati, Welfare Is What Keeps the Wheel Spinning’

Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath’s chaupal and the manner in which it was conducted perfectly encapsulates some of the dominant strands of the BJP’s political mobilisation since 2014 in UP—India’s most populous state and the one that sends the highest number of members to Parliament. First, a strong rural focus in the politics of welfare. Second, an explicit attempt to draw lower castes into the ambit of the BJP and the wider Hindutva umbrella with the messaging of inclusivity. Third, his very presence as chief minister conveyed the party’s implicit message of Hinduness: a saffron-clad monk and the head of the ancient Gorakhnath Peeth, seat of the Nath monastic order, in the seat of power in Lucknow. As Yogi Adityanath said in Pratapgarh, ‘The tradition I come from has for centuries been working with society’s deprived Dalits, sitting among them and running a campaign of “Alakh Niranjan” [a term traditionally used by Nath yogis as a synonym for the Creator]. I have come to carry forward that same tradition. This for me is a way of seva [service], not politics.’[2]

The BJP’s electoral dominance in the Hindi heartland generally, and UP specifically, has powered its political ascendance nationally since 2014. It was enabled by a complete transformation of the party at many levels. This metamorphosis transformed the BJP into the central pole of politics beyond India’s cities and towns, turning it into the default political party of the village in the Hindi heartland. It has long been seen primarily as an urban-focused party—a tag that was not entirely true even earlier. However, since 2014, under Narendra Modi as prime minister, and Amit Shah as party president (2014–2019), the BJP has made deep changes to its DNA, i.e., its social and cultural composition. This transformation has had a cataclysmic impact on Indian politics.



Part I of this book takes a deep dive into the politics of India’s most populous state as well as the larger Hindi heartland. It is based on